GRAMMATICALIZATION OF MOTION VERBS INTO DIRECTIONAL POSTPOSITI

Authors: Dr. Rekha Sharma, Dr. S. Arokianathan
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ABSTRACT:

This paper investigates the grammaticalization pathways through which full lexical motion verbs in Tangkhul have developed into directional markers, telic aspectual affixes, and spatial postpositions. Drawing on connected texts spanning a century of documentation, we demonstrate that motion verbs specifying vertical axis (ascent/descent) and deictic orientation (centrifugal vs centripetal) systematically fuse with verbal stems to form complex path predicates.

Keywords: Grammaticalization, Motion Verbs, Directionals, Deixis, Spatial Grammar, LTBA

1. LEXICAL SOURCE VERBS & DEICTIC TRAJECTORIES

Tangkhul distinguishes three basic deictic path vectors: (i) Centripetal movement toward speaker (-ung eina ungkaphung), (ii) Centrifugal movement away from speaker (-va eina vazatkasa), and (iii) Altitude-conditioned vectors: ascent uphill (-ka) and descent downhill (-tuk).

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

* **ung-kaphung : to arrive coming home toward speaker**
  Analysis: Centripetal motion.
* **va-zatkasa : to go away departing from speaker**
  Analysis: Centrifugal motion.
* **thuk-kashok : to climb up out of a gorge onto peak**
  Analysis: Ascending vertical vector.

2. VERBAL SERIALISATION & AFFIXATION

In serial verb constructions, the directional verb loses its independent nominal arguments and undergoes phonological reduction into an aspectual clitic. For instance, in ’a ot sa-va-ye’ (He went off to do work), the auxiliary -va marks departure aspect rather than physical walking.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** sa-va-ye : did and departed / went off doing**

Analysis: Grammaticalized departure clitic.

*** thei-shok-e : perceived clearly outward / manifested**

Analysis: Directional verb shok (exit) grammaticalized as telic resultative.

3. TYPOLOGICAL PARALLELS IN TIBETO-BURMAN

The Tangkhul grammaticalization cline [Motion Verb -> Serial Verb -> Directional Affix -> Aspect Marker] directly mirrors paradigms observed in Qiang, Jingpho, and Lahu, providing evidence for areal Tibeto-Burman syntactic evolution.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** kashok (exit) -> -shok (telic completive) : Grammaticalization pathway**

Analysis: Lexical verb to grammatical morpheme.

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